

BETTER VICE CLUB

Learn.WitUS Curriculum

CentenarianOS Academy

Episode 3

Chocolate

"The Food of the Gods"

English Language Arts

Teacher Curriculum Packet

Pilot Edition | 2026-2027

How Better Vice Club Works

Better Vice Club (BVC) is a podcast curriculum that teaches Geography, Social Studies, Economics, and English Language Arts through global commodities. Each episode follows a single substance from its geographic origin through its history, economics, and the literature it has generated. Your packet isolates your subject so you can use it standalone, or coordinate with other departments for a full interdisciplinary unit.

What You Need

- Episode audio linked on the Episode Overview page. Episodes run 35 to 40 minutes. You can use the full episode or specific segments called CUT POINTS.
- This packet. All student-facing materials are here, ready to print or share digitally.
- No additional materials required for core activities.

CUT POINTS

Each episode is divided into labeled segments. You don't need to play the full episode. CUT-3D is the Economics segment; CUT-3E is ELA, and so on. Start times are on the Episode Overview page.

The Four BVC Patterns

These patterns repeat across all three seasons of BVC covering 21 episodes:

- Geography Insists. The physical landscape determines what can grow and how.
- Cultivation Begins Sacred. Most commodities begin as ceremonial practice before they become commercial products.
- Labor Captures the Smallest Share. Producers earn the least. Brands and retailers earn the most.
- What Gets Burned, What Gets Saved. Who controls the narrative about a commodity shapes its history.

BVC is produced by Anthony McDonald in Indianapolis, Indiana. All content is documented with peer-reviewed APA citations. No fabricated stories or unnamed expert characters appear in any episode. The curriculum brand is Learn.WitUS, hosted at CentenarianOS.com/academy.

Episode 3 Overview: Chocolate

Detail	Information
Episode title	The Food of the Gods
Season	Season 1: Daily Rituals
Full runtime	35 to 40 minutes
Subjects	Geography, Social Studies, Economics, ELA (all four in one episode)
Audio access	CentenarianOS.com/academy or ask your BVC contact for the file
Recommended grade	9 to 12 (Indiana Academic Standards aligned)

Segment Map

Use CUT POINTS to navigate directly to your subject without playing the full episode.

Cut ID	Segment Title	Start Time	Duration	Subject
CUT-3A	Cold Open: The Price of Gods	0:00	2 min	All subjects
CUT-3B	The Cacao Belt	2:00	8 min	Geography
CUT-3C	From Sacred Drink to Slave Trade	10:00	8 min	Social Studies
CUT-3D	The \$161 Billion Bar	18:00	8 min	Economics
CUT-3E	The Gods Write Back	26:00	8 min	ELA
CUT-3F	The Conscious Bar (Closing)	34:00	2 min	All subjects

Episode Summary

Episode 3 follows cacao from Mayan ceremonial centers in Mesoamerica, where it was currency and sacred drink, through the colonial plantation economy that moved production to West Africa, to a \$161.5 billion global industry where Ivory Coast farmers earn less than \$1 per day. The episode asks why the people who grow chocolate have never tasted it.

Cross-curricular note: If colleagues in other departments are also piloting BVC, their students are studying the same episode through different lenses. Episode 3 connects directly to Episode 1 (Coffee) and Episode 4 (Sugar) as part of a three-episode arc on colonial commodities.

ELA Vocabulary and Rhetorical Framework

Introduce these terms before the ELA segment (CUT-3E, starting at 26:00).

Term	Definition	Chocolate Application
Primary source	An original document, artifact, or testimony from the time period being studied.	Florentine Codex (Aztec perspective); Cortes's letters (colonizer perspective); modern company annual reports.
Positionality	The idea that every text is written from a specific social and historical position that shapes what the writer includes, omits, and how they frame events.	The Florentine Codex and Cortes's letter describe the same ceremony from radically different positions and produce radically different texts.
Cultural appropriation in marketing	When brands use elements of a culture's identity or heritage in commercial marketing without attribution, consent, or economic benefit to that culture.	Chocolate brands using Maya or Aztec imagery in packaging without acknowledging those communities or compensating them.
Magical realism	A literary genre incorporating fantastical elements into realistic settings, often associated with Latin American literature.	Laura Esquivel's <i>Like Water for Chocolate</i> uses food, including chocolate, as a vehicle for magical events rooted in Mexican cultural tradition.
Supply chain narrative	The story a brand tells about where its product comes from. It typically emphasizes romance and origin while making labor conditions invisible.	Premium chocolate brands show ancient traditions and artisan farmers while omitting poverty wages and child labor statistics.
Counter-narrative	A text that challenges, complicates, or directly contradicts a dominant narrative.	A fair trade cooperative's farmer testimony is a counter-narrative to a chocolate company's origin marketing.

Investigative journalism	Journalism that uses systematic research to uncover hidden or suppressed information, often about institutional wrongdoing.	Reporting on child labor in the cacao industry has driven corporate accountability efforts even when voluntary reform has failed.
Genre	A category of text defined by consistent conventions of form, style, and audience expectations.	Sacred ceremonial text, colonial letter, children's fiction, magical realist novel, and corporate marketing are all genres that have been applied to chocolate.
Rhetorical analysis	Systematic examination of how language is used to persuade, including which strategies are used and why they work.	The core skill applied to all primary source documents in this packet.
Oral tradition	The transmission of knowledge, history, and cultural practices through spoken word rather than written records.	Most pre-colonial Maya cacao knowledge was transmitted orally. Burning the codices didn't destroy everything because communities remembered.

Primary Source Collection: Chocolate Across Genres

Document 1: Florentine Codex on Cacao (c. 1570)

Friar Bernardino de Sahagun compiled this from accounts provided by Aztec informants after the conquest.

"He who sells cacao... grinds it, pulverizes it, separates it. He makes cacao with water; he makes it frothy, he aerates it, he fills it, he strains it, he stirs it. He sells it with ground maize, with ground seeds, with chile, with water, with nothing...

Green cacao: poisonous, dangerous, not to be drunk... He who drinks too much of it, it harms him, makes him dizzy, confuses him, makes him sick."

-- Florentine Codex, Book 10, c. 1570

Context: The Codex documents cacao as a sophisticated, regulated product with quality distinctions, preparation methods, and known risks. It was not a drink for everyone. This is among the few surviving primary sources with an Indigenous perspective on cacao, mediated through a Spanish friar's compilation.

Document 2: Hernan Cortes to King Charles V of Spain (1519)

"The great Moctezuma... was served a drink made of cacao that was said to give wisdom and vigor to those who drink it, and always after dinner a great quantity of it was brought to him in cups of finest gold. He was served with more than fifty great jars of good cacao frothed up, and he drank of it."

-- Hernan Cortes, Second Letter to Charles V, 1519

Context: Cortes frames chocolate through gold, royalty, and power. His description sparks European elite interest. He doesn't mention the ceremonial or community meaning of cacao in Aztec life.

Document 3: Charlie and the Chocolate Factory (Roald Dahl, 1964)

Dahl's novel places a magical chocolate factory in a world of pure fantasy: imagination, abundance, and moral reward. The novel doesn't address where the cacao comes from, who grows it, or how it's processed.

The Oompa Loompas in the original text were described as a tribe from 'Loompaland' whom Wonka 'rescued.' Dahl revised the portrayal in later editions. The novel has shaped generations of emotional associations: chocolate equals wonder, childhood magic, and just reward.

Analytical question: What does Charlie and the Chocolate Factory teach readers to feel about chocolate? What does it actively prevent them from thinking about? How does a beloved children's book function as a supply chain narrative?

Document 4: Like Water for Chocolate (Laura Esquivel, 1989)

This Mexican novel uses food, including chocolate, as a vehicle for magical realism rooted in Mexican cultural tradition. The protagonist Tita pours her emotions into everything she cooks, and those emotions are absorbed by everyone who eats her food. Chocolate carries desire, memory, and the spiritual dimensions of daily life.

Unlike Dahl's novel, Esquivel's places chocolate within a specific cultural and geographic context: northern Mexico, early 20th century. The chocolate carries meaning precisely because the character's relationship to food is embedded in cultural practice rather than commercial fantasy.

Analytical question: Compare Dahl's chocolate (magic and reward, origin unknown) with Esquivel's chocolate (memory, desire, and cultural practice in a specific place and time). What does each novel's framing of chocolate reveal about its relationship to the commodity's actual history and geography?

ELA Activity: Five Lenses on Chocolate

Time: 40 to 45 minutes. Materials: this packet. Optional: physical chocolate packaging for analysis.

Task Overview

Chocolate has been written about in sacred ceremonial texts, colonial conquest letters, children's fiction, magical realist literature, investigative journalism, and corporate marketing. Each genre makes different choices about what to include, omit, and emphasize. Students apply genre analysis to five texts about the same substance.

Step 1: Genre Identification (10 minutes)

Students read the four documents in the Primary Source Collection plus examine one modern chocolate brand's packaging or website About page (teacher provides or students search on a device). For each text, they identify:

- Genre: sacred text, colonial letter, children's fiction, magical realist novel, or corporate marketing?
- Author's position: Who is writing? What's their relationship to chocolate?
- Primary audience: Who is this written for?
- What does this text want the reader to feel about chocolate?

Step 2: The Omission Chart (15 minutes)

Students identify what each genre includes and what it omits. Teacher can draw this comparison chart on the board:

Genre	Includes	Omits
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Florentine Codex (sacred text)	Preparation method; quality distinctions; known risks; social regulation	European perspective; commercial context; colonial future
Cortes's letter (colonial)	Royal luxury; gold cups; power and vigor; exoticism	Ceremonial meaning; community governance; Indigenous perspective
Charlie and the Chocolate Factory (children's fiction)	Imagination; abundance; reward; fantasy factory	Cacao origins; farmer wages; supply chain; West Africa
Like Water for Chocolate (magical realism)	Cultural memory; specific place; emotional power of food; Mexican tradition	Industrial supply chain; colonial history; contemporary poverty
Corporate 'About' page (marketing)	Origin story; artisan farmers; ancient traditions; sustainability claims	Farmer daily wages; child labor data; supply chain economics; profit margins

Discussion: What's the pattern? What does every genre that reaches a mass consumer audience tend to omit?

Step 3: The Counter-Narrative (10 minutes)

Investigative journalism exists specifically to fill the omissions of official and commercial narratives. The 2001 BBC documentary 'Slavery: A Global Investigation' first brought widespread public attention to child labor in West African cacao. Despite decades of journalism and corporate pledges, 1.56 million children were still documented in cacao labor in 2020.

- Why does investigative journalism fill the gaps that other genres leave? What does this tell us about genre and power?
- Corporate pledges to eliminate child labor by 2010, then 2020, then 2025, haven't been met. What's the difference between a pledge and a commitment? What rhetorical work does a pledge do even when it isn't kept?

Step 4: Writing (10 minutes)

Students write 150 to 200 words responding to one of these prompts:

- Option A: Write the chocolate bar wrapper text that's both fully honest about the supply chain and still makes someone want to buy the bar. What do you keep from conventional marketing? What do you add? Can a product be sold on the truth of its supply chain?

- Option B: Write a 150-word counter-narrative to any one of the four primary source documents. If you choose the Cortes letter, write the account Aztec merchants might have given of the same encounter. If you choose Charlie and the Chocolate Factory, write the paragraph describing where Wonka's cacao actually comes from.
- Option C: Write a brief scene from a magical realist story set in Ivory Coast where cacao carries specific cultural memory and emotion. What emotion does it carry? What memory? How does placing magical realism in the country that grows 42 percent of the world's chocolate change the genre?

ELA Knowledge Checks

Use as an exit ticket, short quiz, or discussion prompt. Answer key follows.

1. Compare the Florentine Codex and Cortes's letter as primary sources on Aztec chocolate. What does each include and omit? What does comparing the two documents reveal about how positionality shapes historical texts?

2. What does Charlie and the Chocolate Factory teach readers to feel about chocolate, and what does the novel actively prevent them from thinking about? Use the concept of supply chain narrative in your answer.

3. Investigative journalism about child labor in cacao has been published since 2001. Corporate pledges to eliminate child labor by 2010 and 2020 both failed. In three to four sentences, apply genre analysis to explain what rhetorical work corporate pledges are doing and why that genre hasn't produced the outcomes the journalism documents as necessary.

Answer Key (teacher reference only)

Q1 expected answer:

Florentine Codex includes: detailed preparation methods, variety distinctions, known risks, social regulation, quality grading. It treats cacao as a sophisticated cultural practice. Cortes's letter includes: quantity consumed by Montezuma, gold cups, the claim of wisdom and vigor. It treats cacao as an exotic luxury associated with royal power worth conquering. The Codex omits the colonial future arriving. Cortes omits the ceremonial and community meaning. The comparison reveals: positionality shapes what's visible in a text. The Codex describes a practice from inside its culture. Cortes describes the same practice as an outsider evaluating its value for conquest.

Q2 expected answer:

Charlie and the Chocolate Factory teaches readers to feel wonder, excitement, abundance, and moral clarity (good children are rewarded). It prevents readers from thinking about: where cacao grows, who grows it, how much they're paid, and what their children's lives look like. The novel functions as a supply chain narrative by making chocolate emotionally associated with imagination and childhood magic rather than with geography, labor, and economics. It doesn't lie about the supply chain. It renders the supply chain invisible.

Q3 expected answer:

Corporate pledges function in the genre of public commitment, which carries different conventions than legally binding contracts or regulatory requirements. A pledge creates reputational benefit at the moment of announcement and allows companies to claim good intentions without triggering enforcement mechanisms. When pledges fail, companies can make new pledges. Investigative journalism documents outcomes; pledges document intentions. The gap between them persists because pledges are a rhetorical form designed to perform accountability without binding the company to it. As long as consumer demand

doesn't require verified outcomes (rather than stated commitments), the genre works for the companies that use it.

Indiana ELA Standards Alignment

Standard	Description	Where Addressed
11-12.RI.2.1	Cite strong textual evidence to support analysis	Primary source analysis questions require specific textual evidence from each document
11-12.RI.3.1	Analyze how author's choices shape meaning and style	Florentine Codex vs. Cortes comparison; genre analysis across five texts
11-12.RL.2.2	Determine themes and analyze their development across a text	Chocolate as theme in Dahl vs. Esquivel; how genre shapes thematic meaning
11-12.W.3.2	Write informative/explanatory texts to examine complex ideas clearly	Step 4 writing options A, B, and C
11-12.W.4.1	Write arguments to support claims with valid reasoning and evidence	Knowledge check Q3 requires evidence-based rhetorical analysis
11-12.SL.2.1	Initiate and participate in collaborative discussions	Genre identification activity; counter-narrative discussion
11-12.L.3.1	Apply understanding of rhetoric to reading and writing	Genre, positionality, supply chain narrative, and counter-narrative applied across all documents

Reviewer's Feedback Form

Your feedback directly shapes the Learn.WitUS curriculum. Please complete this form after using the materials with students.

DIGITAL VERSION: Scan the QR code below or visit the link provided by your BVC contact. Responses feed directly into a shared spreadsheet for curriculum improvement.

[QR CODE]

About You

1. Subject you teach:

2. Grade level(s) in this pilot:

3. Approximate number of students who used this material:

About the Materials

4. Which segment(s) or activities did you use?

5. Did students have sufficient background knowledge to engage? What was missing or what helped?

6. Were the Indiana Standards alignments accurate for how you teach this standard?

Student Engagement

7. Scale 1 to 5: How well did the episode hold student attention? (1 = struggled, 5 = highly engaged.) Notes:

8. What specific activity or discussion moment generated the most student response?

Usability

9. Would you use this as a standalone lesson, a unit anchor, or a recurring series? Why?

10. The single change that would make this most usable in your classroom next year:

Overall

11. Would you recommend this curriculum to a colleague? What would you say?

Responses are confidential and used only to improve Learn.WitUS curriculum. Thank you for your time and expertise. Anthony McDonald, Better Vice Club